

Mining Haiphong Harbor

The port of Haiphong, on the Gulf of Tonkin, provided the entry point for the major share of North Vietnam's imports, in particular of supplies from its ally the Soviet Union. Disruption of this lifeline to the North became a priority for the United States.

◀◀ BEFORE

Joint Chiefs of Staff contingency plans dating back to 1965 regularly envisioned sealing off North Vietnam's Haiphong harbor, by mining or blockade.

THUNDER ROLLS OVER HAIPHONG

The **Rolling Thunder** bombing campaign in the summer of 1967 included **major attacks** on Haiphong in order to disrupt the import of supplies from North Vietnam's allies and therefore degrade its war effort. The strikes included dropping land mines along key transportation routes such as the **Ho Chi Minh Trail** and also "seeding" mines in the inland waterways of North Vietnam.



PRO-WAR BUTTON, 1965

In the spring of 1972, President Nixon, fresh from the diplomatic triumph of his visit to China in February, thought he had isolated the North Vietnamese regime. But the Easter Offensive forced back the South Vietnamese on front after front. On April 5, Joint Chiefs of Staff Chairman Admiral Moorer asserted that the president wanted new options. The first proposal would have been a focused bombing campaign like that of 1967. The second idea, named Pocket Money, envisioned mining Haiphong and other North Vietnamese ports. Nixon accepted the latter. Secretary of Defense Melvin Laird protested that mining Haiphong would achieve little unless North Vietnam was also bombed. Nixon promptly approved plans for the first "Linebacker" operation of bombing the North.

Diplomatic moves

Under international law, mining was an act of war. However, no state of war existed between the United States and any country in Southeast Asia. A full menu of diplomatic notices and private meetings therefore accompanied Pocket Money. Nixon also surrounded